

Glossary

Artery A thick-walled blood vessel that carries blood from the heart to the tissues.

Axon A long fiber that extends from the cell body of a neuron and carries signals to other nerve cells.

Bacteria A group of small, single-celled microorganisms, some of which cause disease in humans.

Bone marrow A soft tissue found in the spaces within bones.

Calcium A mineral used by the body to build bones and teeth.

Capillary A microscopic blood vessel that links the smallest arteries to the smallest veins, and delivers blood to tissue cells.

Carbohydrate A group of substances found in food and inside the body. It includes sugars, such as glucose—the body's store of energy.

Carbon dioxide A gas that is the waste product of energy release inside cells.

Cardiac Of or relating to the heart.

Cartilage A tough, flexible tissue that helps support the body and covers the ends of bones in joints.

Cell One of the trillions of microscopic living units that make up the body.

Chromosome One of 46 packages of DNA found in the nucleus of each cell.

Chyme A creamy liquid that is produced by the part-digestion of food in the stomach.

Cilia Tiny hairlike structures found on some tissue. They wave to move things, such as mucus, across their surface.

Collagen A tough protein that makes up the fibers that strengthen tendons, ligaments, and cartilage.

CT (computed tomography) scan A method of producing 2-D and 3-D images of body tissues and organs.

Cytoplasm The jellylike fluid found between the membrane and nucleus of a cell.

Dendrite A short fiber that carries incoming signals from other nerve cells to the cell body of a neuron.

Dermis The deeper, thicker layer of skin, below the epidermis. It contains sensory receptors and blood vessels.

Digestion The process by which food is broken down into simple nutrients that can be absorbed into the bloodstream and used by the body.

Digestive enzyme A substance that speeds up the breakdown of food molecules.

DNA (deoxyribonucleic acid) A long molecule found inside the nucleus of body cells. It contains the coded instructions needed to build and run a body.

Embryo A developing baby between the time it arrives in the uterus and eight weeks after fertilization.

Energy The fuel that comes from eating food. It is essential for keeping the body's cells working and alive.

Enzyme A protein that speeds up chemical reactions inside the body.

Epidermis The thin protective layer of the skin.

Fat A group of substances found in food and inside the body. Fat stores energy and insulates the body.

Fertilization The joining together of a male sperm and a female egg to make a new human being.

Fetus The name given to a developing baby from the ninth week after fertilization until birth.

Gastric Of or relating to the stomach.

Gene One of 23,000 coded instructions stored in the DNA that makes up the chromosomes inside a cell's nucleus.

Germ A common name given to microorganisms that cause disease.

Gland A group of cells that make and release specific substances such as hormones and enzymes.

Glucose A type of sugar found in the bloodstream that is the main source of energy for body cells.

Hemoglobin A red, oxygen-carrying protein found inside red blood cells.

Hepatic Of or relating to the liver.